

History of Line Dancing

There are several different theories as to how and when line dancing originated. Line dancing has many forms and has existed for thousands of years in many parts of the world.

- 1650 English County Dancing (first known line dance instructions were written in a book of dance sheets). Country line dancing appears to have originated in Europe and arrived in the United States with the settlers who immigrated to America.
- 1800s Western and Country dancing became very popular from the Midwest to the West Coast. Most of these dances were couple dances that followed set steps, some were line dances.
- 1950s – 1960s Line dances like **The Madison**, **Hully Gully**, and **San Francisco Stomp** were introduced.
- 1970s Line dances were choreographed to many popular music (e.g., pop, rock and roll, swing, disco, Latin, and Jazz). **Cowboy Boogie** and the **L.A. Hustle** appeared which combined country music with Disco songs.
- 1980s A few more dozen line dances for country songs were developed and Country line dancing that is recognized today was probably born in Nashville, Tennessee. Jim Ferrazano allegedly wrote the line dance steps to **Tush Push** on a napkin. Melanie Greenwood, a famous line dance choreographer tested the Tush Push and brought it to the floor. Later she wrote the line dance instructions to **Achy Breaky Heart** by Billy Ray Cyrus. This hit song and line dance became a huge hit in 1982 and catapulted line dancing into the mainstream.

Line dancing today has very traditional dances to country music as well as popular line dances to non-country music. Line dancing is popular in:

- country-western dancing nightclubs
- weddings
- social clubs
- ballrooms
- parties worldwide
- health and fitness in gyms
- fitness clubs
- community centers and recreational programs

In more recent years, music has been written to cater to dancers whereas originally dances were written to cater to the music. This has opened the doors for some dances to be done to the music of choice of the dancer.

Country line dancing has spread to other parts of the world but predominately remains in the United States, Australia, and Europe. Country line dancing's arrival to Europe was aided by the arrival of Country Music Television in 1998. In 2014, Durham, N.C. was declared the line dancing capital of America after a capital ranking of MeetUp groups.

Line dancing is popular because it is easy to learn and avoids the problem of an imbalance of male to female partners that troubles ballroom and social partner dancers. Country line dancing is often partnered with other country western dances such as the country two-step, western promenade dances, and western-style variations of the waltz, swing, and polka.